

Chapter 50: Probing

Chu Qing Qiu did not speak again, but Ning Fu Yi rolled over and got out of bed. Her body dissolved into pale pink light and shadow, quickly passing through the wall. She appeared behind the door of the next room, and the originally gloomy place suddenly lost some of its sinister atmosphere.

"Divine Venerable, move over there a bit." She said with a smile.

"You're acting recklessly again. If immortal power is detected, I'm afraid we won't be able to lure out the one who will make a move." Chu Qing Qiu said.

However, though she scolded with her mouth, she did not drive Ning Fu Yi away. Instead, she moved her body aside, leaving a warm spot.

For some reason, Ning Fu Yi always wanted to laugh. She lowered her head to hide her smile, walked close to the bed, and gently sat down.

Chu Qing Qiu had now shrunk into the corner of the wall, placing the white bone¹ back at her waist. Usually when she sat or stood, she had a natural noble bearing. This curled-up posture was not often seen.

But seeing her so cool and aloof yet curled up like this was quite lively, Ning Fu Yi thought.

"I heard it too." Ning Fu Yi suddenly spoke. She casually rested her head against the dusty wall, her fingers beating time to the song.

No wonder Chu Qing Qiu was frightened by it—that voice was indeed eerie, a soft, enchanting child's voice. But it didn't sound as clear as what the children sang during the day.

Moreover, it didn't seem to come from outside the door, but rather lingered right by their ears, as if a child was crouched on her back, singing eerily into her ear.

Just as Chu Qing Qiu had said, it stopped abruptly at "sixth," and a cold wind blew from somewhere, causing the temperature to drop suddenly.

"This thing certainly knows how to create mystery." Ning Fu Yi laughed. She leaned closer to Chu Qing Qiu and started chatting: "Divine Venerable is afraid of ghosts, so how did you handle ghost troubles when subduing demons and eliminating evil in the past?"

Chu Qing Qiu's mouth tightened slightly. Ning Fu Yi speaking so directly made her somewhat embarrassed, but she still opened her mouth: "I wasn't afraid before."

Wasn't afraid before? So she only started being afraid now. Perhaps it had something to do with the Heartless Path². Ning Fu Yi thought.

Those who cultivated the Heartless Path had emotions and feelings that were much fainter than ordinary people, so naturally they couldn't feel fear. This meant that Chu Qing Qiu was no longer cultivating the Heartless Path.

While she was pondering this, footsteps suddenly came from the distance. Chu Qing Qiu suddenly placed her fingertip on her lips, signaling Ning Fu Yi to be quiet.

Chu Qing Qiu's eyes sparkled brightly in the dim room. Her mouth was rarely rosy, and when her clean fingernails were placed by her lips, it looked like crystalline dew on a ruby.

Ning Fu Yi held her breath and looked away.

"It's a woman, should be that woman." Chu Qing Qiu used her divine consciousness³ to speak in Ning Fu Yi's ear, "She's entered the room."

"I really want to see what kind of tricks this old witch is planning." Ning Fu Yi also replied using divine consciousness, then silently leaped off the bed and went out through Chu Qing Qiu's door, coming to the pitch-black courtyard. Yawning, she entered from the other side, and indeed found that woman in the room. She was lying on the bed feeling around in shock. When she saw Ning Fu Yi still awake, she looked as if she'd seen a ghost and was so frightened she almost collapsed on the ground.

"Eh, why did you come, aunt?" Ning Fu Yi pretended to wipe away tears from yawning and asked kindly, glancing to see what she was holding in her hand.

It was a bundle of sturdy hemp rope.

After feeling Ning Fu Yi's gaze, the woman quickly hid the hemp rope behind her back, scrambling to her feet with a smile full of wrinkles: "You're awake, young lady? I was worried the room was too shabby for you to sleep well, so I came to check."

"It's fine, it's fine. For travelers, having a place to sleep is already precious." Ning Fu Yi said with a smile, but her eyes held no mirth as she reached out to grab the rope.

However, at this moment, a sharp scream came from next door, mixed with crying and seemingly full of terror. Ning Fu Yi instinctively thought it was from Chu Qing Qiu's side, but when she turned around, she realized the sound came from another direction.

The woman suddenly let out a desperate shout, threw down the rope, and rolled and crawled out the door. All at once, chickens crowed and dogs barked, making quite a racket.

Not knowing what had happened, Ning Fu Yi followed out and ran into Chu Qing Qiu coming out from next door.

The screaming came from the main room. The door was now wide open, with the woman tearing at her own hair at the doorway, crying and cursing. Other villagers were also awakened by the noise, occasionally poking their heads out from behind courtyard walls. Their expressions were not curious, but desperate and numb, accompanied by whispered conversations.

"Such evil! My Da Lang, my Da Lang! Damn thing, gods, bodhisattvas, please save my Da Lang..." The woman collapsed at the door wailing. The child from earlier was now crawling out biting his finger with a blank stare, looking confused.

"Wife, wife, mother, where's my wife!" The commotion also startled the fool Er Lang in the pigsty. He crawled out grinning and tried to throw himself into Ning Fu Yi's arms upon seeing her: "Wife..."

This frightened Ning Fu Yi so much her soul nearly left her body, and she kept dodging backward. Then she saw Chu Qing Qiu kick out, and the fool immediately fell backward into the pigsty, landing head-first in pig manure and losing consciousness.

"Er Lang!" The woman let out another wail, crawled up to look at the pigsty, then turned back pointing at Chu Qing Qiu, her small eyes widening like copper bells: "You, you..."

Chu Qing Qiu disgustedly withdrew her foot and rubbed it on the ground.

"Auntie, so she wanted to tie me up to be that fool's wife." Ning Fu Yi touched her chest, still in the mood to joke, "You just kicked away my husband."

Before she finished speaking, she received another knock on the head, finally closing her mouth and rubbing her forehead with a smile.

If Chu Qing Qiu had hit her a few months ago, she could have gotten angry enough to overturn the entire Jing Mountain Palace. But now, after being hit, she somehow couldn't get angry at all.

Watching Chu Qing Qiu's emotional fluctuations was quite an enjoyable pastime.

"Stop crying." Chu Qing Qiu impatiently commanded, then stepped over the threshold to look into the room. She saw chaos everywhere on the ground, with bedding and pillows all overturned. The woman they had seen during the day lay unconscious with a pale face among the mess, while the baby on the bed let out weak cries.

The man had disappeared.

When Chu Qing Qiu wasn't pretending, her entire being radiated intimidation. Just one sentence made the woman afraid to cry anymore, looking at her in terror.

"What exactly happened here? If you don't explain clearly, I'm afraid even if gods came, they couldn't save you." Chu Qing Qiu said sternly, walking out of the room with its stifling atmosphere with her hands behind her back.

Seeing Chu Qing Qiu's imposing presence and having witnessed her kick away her Er Lang, the woman knew these two were definitely not ordinary women and became afraid. So she dared not be insolent anymore, wiping her nose and opening her red eyes to speak.

"Our village has been haunted by ghosts since a year ago. At first, we only lost some livestock, and the villagers didn't mind. But later people started dying one after another, and that's when we became panicked."

"How did those people die?" Ning Fu Yi asked.

The woman seemed unwilling to recall, her eyes full of fear: "They all died very strangely. Some had their hands and feet cut off, some had their stomachs stuffed with grass like cattle and were stretched to death, and others..."

"Is it related to that song?" Ning Fu Yi interrupted her panicked description.

"Yes, yes, did you hear it too?" The woman looked up searching around the door, finally pointing at a blood-red character with wide eyes, "It's this, this! Anyone whose door shows this character will surely die that night!"

Ning Fu Yi and Chu Qing Qiu looked up in the direction she pointed, and there indeed was a clear number "six" written in fresh blood, hidden on the wall covered with climbing ivy.

It was the part where the song stopped abruptly. What was that song again? Ning Fu Yi frowned trying to remember.

"The sixth one laughs in the cage..." Chu Qing Qiu spoke very quickly, then turned to ask the woman, "Do you have any cages in your house?"

The woman was stunned, then walked toward the back of the house on her small feet: "Yes, yes, we used to take it to the market to put chickens in, it's right..."

Before she could finish speaking, she let out a shrill scream, her steps frantically retreating. She tripped over herself and sat down hard on the ground, so frightened her face was distorted. She could no longer speak, only desperately shouting, appearing mad.

Ning Fu Yi quickly followed to the back of the house, and the horrific scene before her eyes gave even her quite a shock. She saw a bamboo chicken cage carelessly thrown in the grass, with a person stuffed inside. Through the sparse bamboo strips of the cage, she could see a twisted face with eyes bulging as if about to split, seeming to have seen something terrifying.

That cage wasn't large, so to stuff him inside, his limbs had been repeatedly folded up like a cloth doll, filling every gap in the cage.

The smell of blood hit them head-on.

"This thing's methods are truly cruel." Ning Fu Yi said to Chu Qing Qiu. Chu Qing Qiu didn't respond—she seemed about to vomit. So without paying attention to the woman anymore, she turned and went back to the front courtyard.

Ning Fu Yi didn't want to look anymore either. Although she had seen mountains of corpses and seas of blood when she was the Heaven-Slaying Demon God in her previous life, she wasn't a pervert after all, and had no interest in such horrific death scenes.

So she lowered her head and dragged the woman, who had been scared out of her wits, back to the original place. But she saw several villagers had already gathered in the courtyard, pointing at another door and whispering.

Ning Fu Yi dropped the woman and squeezed among them. Chu Qing Qiu also stood among them with a complex expression. They saw that another blood-red character had appeared on the door of the house where the woman originally lived.

"Four." Ning Fu Yi said in surprise.

The surrounding villagers all shook their heads, seeming numb to this matter. After saying a few words, they turned and dispersed. Ning Fu Yi quickly reached out to grab one: "Excuse me..."

"Young lady, you'd better stop meddling. Pack up your things and leave quickly. This place is not suitable for staying long. That thing is very evil—once it leaves this character, it will never stop, whether it's this Zhang woman or her fool Er Lang." The one grabbed was an elderly grandmother with already cloudy eyes, "We can't escape this mountain village, and those who leave also face death."

"All those in the village who were marked with 'four' disappeared. We searched all the nearby mountains but found no trace. I think this Zhang woman won't even leave a corpse behind." Someone else said nearby, sighing and leaving. The grandmother also broke free from Ning Fu Yi and quickly left. Soon the courtyard returned to silence.

Only the hens were still clucking, and the occasional smell of blood wafted over.

"You go to Qiu Lan's room and guard her and the two children." Chu Qing Qiu spoke using divine consciousness, then stepped forward to enter the woman's room. Seeing something was wrong, Ning Fu Yi quickly grabbed her.

"What does Divine Venerable mean by this?" Ning Fu Yi held onto her sleeve and wouldn't let go, also using divine consciousness.

"We came to find that thing. How else can we lure it out if we don't do this?"

"But aren't you afraid of ghosts?" Ning Fu Yi tilted her head, "Why must you personally act to lure out a dirty thing? I can go instead."

"Go back." Chu Qing Qiu's dark eyebrows knitted together as she pushed away Ning Fu Yi, "How could such evil spirits harm this venerable one? You stay here obediently and keep watch."

"You were shaking with fear just now, why put on a strong front!" Ning Fu Yi was completely uncompromising.

The child nearby, seeing them glaring at each other without speaking, hadn't been crying before but now started wailing loudly. Only then did the two of them restrain themselves a bit.

"Ning Fu Yi!" This time Chu Qing Qiu spoke aloud in rebuke, her red lips tightly pressed together in anger at Ning Fu Yi's stubbornness.

"This kind of grunt work has always been done by disciples at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate⁴. Since when does a dignified sect master serve as bait?" Ning Fu Yi continued using divine consciousness, but spoke the last sentence aloud, her phoenix eyes half-raised.

"Could it be that you're so worried about me that you won't let me suffer even a little?"

Not expecting Ning Fu Yi to say such words, Chu Qing Qiu's words were immediately stuck in her throat. For a moment, even with anger, she couldn't vent it. She breathed heavily, suddenly turned around, and said coldly: "If you want to go, then go. When danger comes, don't say I wasn't watching over you properly!"

With that, she picked up the child and walked into the room where the woman lay. The door slammed shut with a bang, and dust and debris fell down with crackling sounds.

Ning Fu Yi stood in place, her phoenix eyes rippling like autumn water, slowly withdrawing her gaze and the smile that had been playing at her lips.

Half of those words were sincere questioning, half were probing—probing what secrets Chu Qing Qiu was hiding.

She looked up at the blood-red character, then threw both the unconscious woman and her fool Er Lang into the pigsty to hide them, before entering the room herself. The room was very dark, so she didn't light a lamp, feeling her way to the bed and lying down fully clothed.

Closing her eyes, she didn't know how long she lay there—so long that Ning Fu Yi almost fell asleep—before the childish singing started again in her ears, giggling as it sang.

"First break the hand, second break the waist, count to three and hang up high. Fourth play with mud, fifth eat grass, the sixth one laughs in the cage. Seven bugs, eight legs, nine mouths croaking..."

The song played twice in her ears, finally stopping at "fourth," followed by dead silence.

The bed made small movements, and Ning Fu Yi knew that what had been an empty space beside her now had something else there!

Footnotes:

1. **White bone (白骨)**: Chu Qing Qiu's weapon/spiritual item, frequently mentioned throughout the story
2. **Heartless Path (无情道)**: A cultivation method that suppresses emotions to achieve greater power and clarity
3. **Divine consciousness (神识)**: A cultivator's spiritual awareness that can be used for communication and sensing
4. **Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门)**: The sect that Ning Fu Yi and Chu Qing Qiu belong to